

Memo

To: Dr. Derek G. Ross, Dr. Stewart Whittemore, and Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: V. Jasey Herrington

Re: Introductory Context Memo, MTPC Defense

Date: January 17th, 2026

Making the Invisible Visible: Why TPC Matters

Technical communication has always been interdisciplinary, serving as a link between complexity and accessibility. My own experience as an academic advisor has also placed me in those liminal spaces where pedagogy, accessibility, and plain language intersect. Throughout my time in the Technical and Professional Communication program at Auburn University, if there is a single thread connecting the issues my portfolio engages in, it is visibility. The visibility of users who are often excluded with their most basic rights ignored, of communication practices that go underappreciated or unacknowledged in higher education, and of technical and professional communication itself as a means essential to make knowledge usable, equitable, and meaningful for all audiences.

Technical and professional communication has recently become more recognized as vital to organizational and professional efficiency, but much of this work remains hidden, undervalued, and unevenly integrated into institutional practice and policy (Willers, 2023). While taking courses as a graduate student, I also advise almost 250 undergraduate students each semester, witnessing firsthand the impact of complex policies, unclear instruction, and inaccessible communication. These barriers to success are found in wide-reaching facets of our world today, and deliberate, audience-centered communication can serve as the means of removing them.

This memo, and in turn my final portfolio, highlights the projects I have worked on during the master's program. This work ranges from collaborative editing assignments and multilingual surveys to plain language policy studies and pedagogical interventions, each illustrating the ways in which technical communication makes visible the needs, rights, and experiences of diverse audiences. Together, they explore how multimodality, accessibility, plain language and pedagogy connect with institutional discourse and collaboration to shape effective messaging.

Challenges in the Field

Specialization over Generalization

One of the defining tensions in TPC lies in balancing identity with interdisciplinarity. As Walton, Moore, and Jones (2019) note in *Technical Communication After the Social Justice Turn*, technical communicators often serve as mediators between subject matter experts and publics, navigating multiple communities of practice. However, as the field becomes more specialized, encompassing UX, editing, content strategy, and design, it risks creating subfields that further separate us from shared rhetorical and functional foundations. In over-specifying professional roles, practitioners can narrow their identities to specific tasks and tools, rather than emphasizing how adaptable our rhetorical skill set is. It can also limit practitioners' ability to transfer skills across contexts, respond to ever evolving professional demands, and engage meaningfully with new skillsets.

Balancing Clarity with Complexity

Another ongoing concern is the idea that we must reconcile clarity and complexity in TPC. Technical communicators are often tasked with "translating" specialized documents into more usable formats, without oversimplifying or erasing context. Adhya (2015) and Clem and Cheek (2022) remind us that clarity is not synonymous with simplification. It requires precision, empathy, and an awareness of audience needs. This challenge is evident across my portfolio, from the *Culinary Chronicles* style guide to my plain language study of the SAP policy. Each project highlights the importance of writing clearly without erasing context.

Accessibility and Ethics in Editing

Accessibility remains one of the most urgent and defining concerns within the field of TPC and in society at large. Whether framed through Section 508 legal compliance or Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles, contemporary accessibility work emphasizes both usability and justice (Rogers-Shaw, 2008). Walton, Moore, and Jones (2019) frame this as not just professional courtesy, but an ethical imperative. Communication needs to be equitable in form and function. Projects in my portfolio such as the Multilingual Survey Design and Pedagogical Intervention extend this idea to linguistic and cognitive accessibility. Translating surveys for ESOL students and using advising tools to demonstrate how accessibility can exceed technical compliance.

From Theory to Practice: My Work in the MTPC Program

Culinary Chronicles, ENGL 7000: Technical Editing

In one of my first courses in the MTPC program, I was tasked with what became one of the more challenging projects during my time as a graduate student: serving as chief editor for a publication that does not exist (i.e., create *something* from nothing). Technical Editing with Dr. Ross required me to not only come to terms with my growing identity as an editor, but also to find ways to incorporate my own philosophies while staying true to the idea of what a good editor, and editing student, should be. One of the first readings came from our textbook *Technical Editing*, where we began to understand what it takes to start from scratch and create

something worth publishing. To begin, we had to understand the rhetorical situation, which refers to the idea that “no document exists in a vacuum” and is instead shaped by its context (Cunningham, et al., 2021, pp.21).

By the second week of class, editing teams were forming, and ideas for publications were taking shape. As a student who always tries to contribute (and struggles with awkward silences), I suggested the idea of a collaborative student cookbook. My groupmates found this idea appealing and not truly understanding the immense work I’d just signed up for, we agreed to form a group that would eventually create the *Culinary Chronicles*.

This project was eye-opening for me in several ways. First, I discovered that I am drawn to the development of systems that make texts more usable, namely developing a style guide and applying principles of copyediting. Both tasks I have come to realize are directly connected to my broader research interests in accessibility and plain language. A well-designed style guide is more than just a tool for design consistency, it can serve as an ethical document that reduces ambiguity and makes content more usable for writers and readers (Adhya, 2015; Clem & Cheek, 2022). Similarly, copyediting requires editors to hone their ability to anticipate the needs of diverse audiences and make choices that prioritize clarity over unnecessary complexity.

The second way in which ENGL 7000 helped me better understand the role of technical communicators and the editing process as a means for increasing visibility for all users was through the collaborative requirements of our project. Working as the managing editor on *Culinary Chronicles* revealed how editing is oftentimes a social and rhetorical act, requiring negotiation, compromise, and an awareness of multiple perspectives (Amare & Manning, 2009). I learned to balance my own beliefs with the needs and ideas of my peers, recognizing that technical editing is as much about ethics and relationships as it is about precise language use.

Advising as Pedagogy, ENGL 7870: Special Topics in English

Beginning in ENGL 7040 (Composition: Issues and Approaches), I have consistently worked on a scholarly article titled *Advising as Pedagogy: Facilitating Transfer of Learning and Academic Literacies in One-on-One Spaces*. I further explored this topic and project in ENGL 7870. This paper explores how academic advising can serve as a site of pedagogical instruction, particularly for students who are first-generation or transfer students. My research question asked: “How can academic advisors help students recognize patterns in their learning and behavior and utilize that knowledge to make connections across courses and throughout their academic and professional careers?”

In the paper, I draw on a key idea within Technical and Professional Communication: the need to cultivate and recognize rhetorical and pedagogical opportunities outside of traditional classroom spaces. As I wrote in my reflection for the advising-as-pedagogy project, “I wanted to craft an argument that shows how what is done in advising, when utilized effectively, can be as pedagogically impactful as classroom teaching. I wanted to show that advising is not only administrative, but rhetorical, and that advisors constantly renegotiate their audience, purpose, and context just as writing instructors do.”

This paper illustrates how rhetorical practice extends beyond conventional academic boundaries. By analyzing advising as a rhetorical act grounded in audience awareness, clarity, and transfer of learning, I positioned it as a form of technical communication that embodies many of the field's central values, including usability, accessibility, and responsiveness to context.

More broadly, this work reflects on an ongoing challenge within the professional field of Technical Communication. While our discipline values applied, real-world communication, the scholarly contributions are often unacknowledged when they occur outside of the traditional classroom or conference setting. My project argues that “invisible spaces” such as student services are not merely peripheral to TPC, they can serve as extensions of it.

Multilingual Survey, ENGL 7060: Document Design

Document Design offered many opportunities to hone both my understanding of design principles and how to apply them in the most beneficial and accessible format. My final project, a multilingual survey client design project, represents one of the most applied and collaborative experiences of my graduate study. My partner and I worked with Metropolitan Community College's adult education program in Omaha, Nebraska, and we were tasked with designing a multilingual digital survey to collect post-program data from ESOL and GED students.

The original idea for our document was an instructor training manual, but a conversation with the client revealed their most pressing need was actually a more culturally and linguistically accessible way to gather follow-up data for funding and assessment purposes. The information needed for their accrediting bodies required detailed and very personal information about graduates' financial and employment status after completing the program. While this information is helpful in establishing the success of the adult learner program, it also meant that respondents, most of them non-native English speakers, were asked to provide information that could lead them to becoming targets for other federal and legal organizations.

In this project, our actions directly impacted users' experiences and institutional decision-making. Designing for these adult learners required balancing technical accuracy with empathy and cultural awareness. Our design process followed the Planned Rapid Document Development (PRDD) model described in Kimball and Hawkins (2008) which emphasizes iterative collaboration and continual client feedback. However, the most difficult part of this project was not technical, it was linguistic and ethical. Translating and localizing the survey helped reveal how English-dominant institutional systems can unintentionally exclude participants whose lived experiences fall outside the “standard user”. By using Jotform's translation feature, conducting usability testing with ESOL students, and revising based on Dr. Whittemore's feedback, we designed a survey that invited participation rather than required it.

This project directly engages one of the major challenges I see in Technical and Professional Communication: ensuring accessibility not only through technology, but through language and cultural awareness. This mirrors the broader conversation around social justice in technical

communication (Walton, Moore & Jones, 2019) and aligns with my portfolio's main theme of visibility— making visible the users, linguistic requirements, and experiences that mainstream communication practices often overlook.

This experience also required our team to argue for the rhetorical legitimacy of our deliverable. As Dr. Whittemore noted in his feedback, “even though your deliverable didn’t give you much opportunity to exercise traditional document design skills...the experience of negotiating with a client to meet a genuine need and then to design and test a user interface fully justifies the slight lack of orthodoxy.” This comment helped affirm the project’s impact as a document not only in visual composition, but as a form of ethical and community-centered communication.

Ultimately, this project represents how technical communication can make a tangible difference in users’ lives when it values accessibility alongside design principles. Visibility is not just about making text usable; it is about making participation possible.

Heuristic Analysis of SAP Policy, ENGL 7010 Technical Communication: Issues and Approaches

The SAP study was developed as my Individual Research project in ENGL 7010 Technical Communication: Issues and Approaches. The Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) policy is a federally mandated institutional guideline for students who utilize federal financial aid such as Pell Grants. I was drawn to this study because of my professional experience helping students navigate dense institutional communication while in high-stakes and vulnerable positions that could influence their ability to stay enrolled in their studies.

I utilized theoretical frameworks from Lowenstein on advisors as teachers, Nielsen’s usability theory (2009), and Tinto’s research on the attrition rates of undergraduate students (1993). Then, following best practices and course policies, I collaborated with an AI tool to develop a heuristic based on plain language principles of clarity and accessibility to research the SAP communication practices of four Alabama universities (Auburn, University of Alabama, University of North Alabama, and Alabama State University) against a best-practice model from University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. That model is a practitioner-developed resource guide. This heuristic included seven categories including findability, institutional support resources, and appeals process information and was weighted by real-world needs of an assumed audience.

I followed a three-step process to evaluate each of the universities. First, a surface level scan to see how different universities format their SAP policy communication, then I applied the weighted heuristic. Finally, I made a cross-institutional comparison to score them and write up potential recommendations for improvement.

Pedagogical Intervention, ENGL 7040 Composition Theory: Issues and Approaches

The Pedagogical Intervention project completed in ENGL 7040 builds on my earlier work positioning advising as an instructional practice by demonstrating how rhetorical and

pedagogical theory can be enacted in real-world, non-classroom contexts. In this assignment, I developed a fictionalized advising conversation to showcase how multimodal communication, Universal Design for Learning (UDL), and multiliteracies pedagogy can create a more accessible and meaningful student experience. As I wrote in my introduction, “students rarely act on information after encountering it only once,” which highlights the rhetorical importance of repetition and multimodal reinforcement, key strategies in technical communication and pedagogy.

Throughout the scenario, I embedded theoretical connections to Yancey, the New London Group, and Wysocki to showcase relationships between advising and rhetorical situations. By narrating and annotating a conversation between “Jasey” and “Skylar”, I demonstrated how concepts such as situated learning operates in applied contexts. These annotations served a dual purpose: they revealed how pedagogical theories guide my professional decisions and they model how reflection can make behind the scenes rhetorical work visible.

A Multi-Vocal Exploration of Advising Pedagogy also connects to broader TPC ideas surrounding accessibility and plain language. My decision to pair visual GPA tools and written follow-ups reflects UDL principles, specifically providing multiple means of representation to support diverse learners. These techniques mirror plain language: make information usable and actionable for varied audiences. It helps reaffirm the arguments of my portfolio, which is that technical and professional communication’s value lies not only in its ability to create usable texts, but in the ways, it shapes understanding, fosters learning in non-traditional contexts, and amplifies voices that might otherwise remain silenced.

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